

ALTHOUGH JET AIRCRAFT played only a marginal role in World War II, by the end of the war it was clear that jet propulsion would hold the key to air supremacy in any future conflict. Piston-engined, propeller-driven aircraft had been pushed to the limit of their potential. Jets could fly faster – in November 1945 a British jet fighter, the Gloster Meteor, set a new official world speed record of 606.25mph (975.46kph) – and operate at higher altitudes.

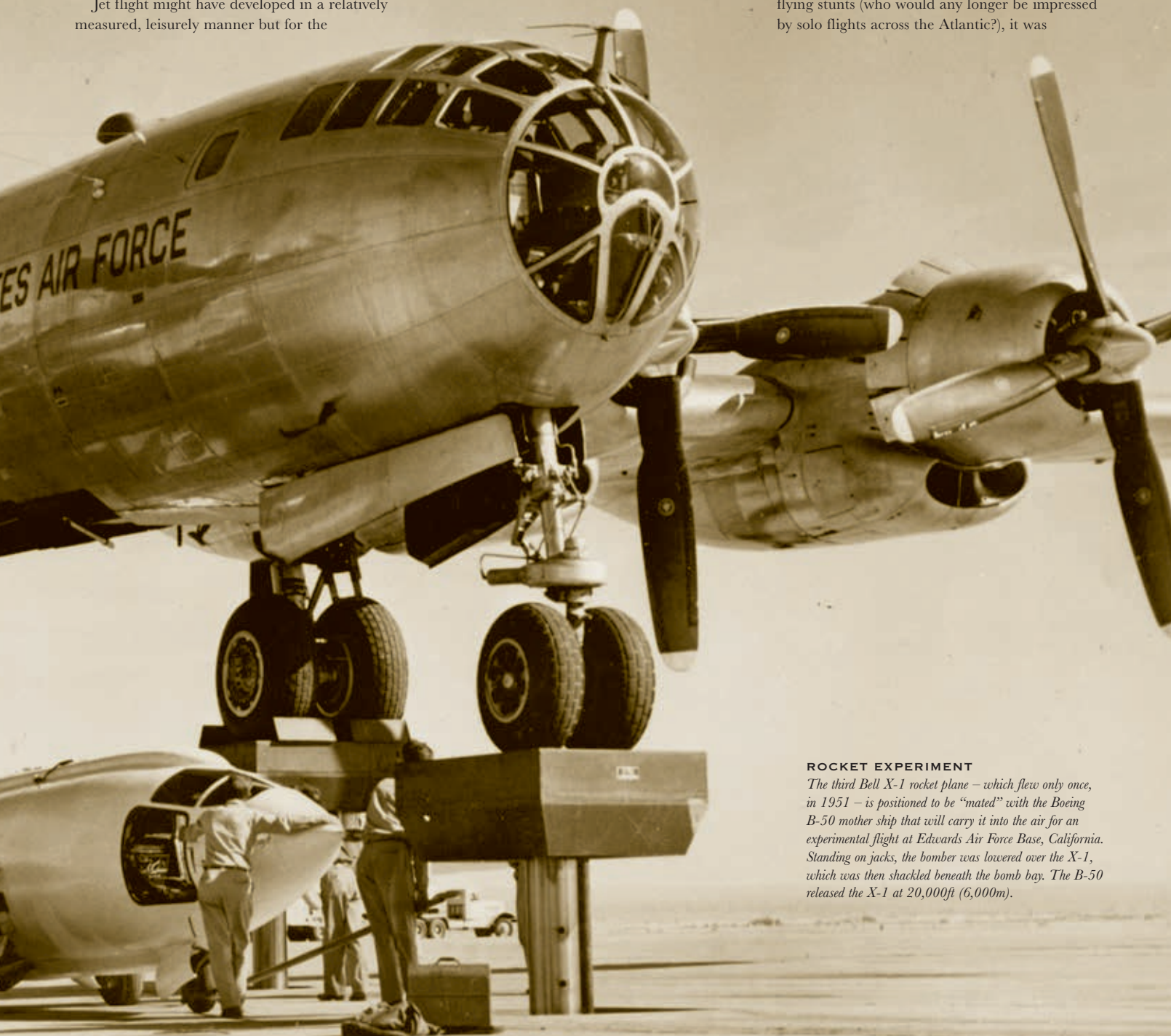
Jet flight might have developed in a relatively measured, leisurely manner but for the

onset of the Cold War through the second half of the 1940s. The deepening mutual suspicions of the Soviet Union on one side, and the United States and the countries of Western Europe on the other, gave urgency to the quest for progress in military aviation technology. World War II had shown what a country with command of the air could do to its enemies. Even in countries officially at peace, there was a readiness to take

calculated risks with pilots' lives in the pursuit of a level of performance that might ultimately give an air force the edge over its potential foes. Jet development was to be rapid, secretive, and costly.

New heroes

In the race to develop high-performance jets, test pilots became the new heroes of aviation. With no hot war to fight in (most of the time), and with the decline of air racing and of long-distance flying stunts (who would any longer be impressed by solo flights across the Atlantic?), it was



ROCKET EXPERIMENT

The third Bell X-1 rocket plane – which flew only once, in 1951 – is positioned to be “mated” with the Boeing B-50 mother ship that will carry it into the air for an experimental flight at Edwards Air Force Base, California. Standing on jacks, the bomber was lowered over the X-1, which was then shackled beneath the bomb bay. The B-50 released the X-1 at 20,000ft (6,000m).